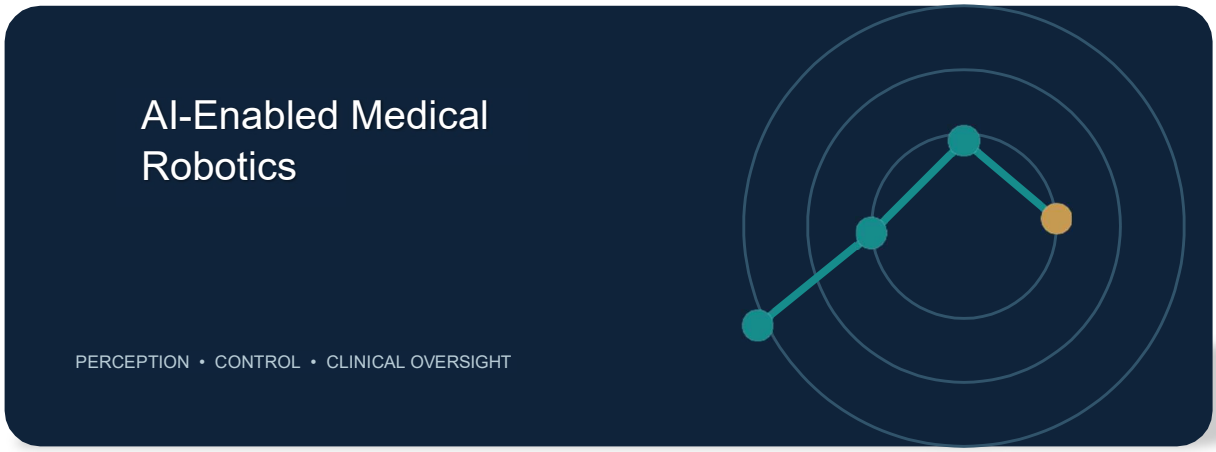
AIR UNIVERSITY / ISLAMABAD, PAKISTAN

AI-Enabled Medical Robotics

Transforming Surgery, Rehabilitation, and Assistive Healthcare



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A critical review of the technologies, clinical applications, evidence, limitations and governance shaping intelligent medical robots.

Executive perspective

Medical robots are increasingly capable of sensing, measuring and adapting. This report examines where AI adds value and where the evidence still requires restraint. It distinguishes deployed robotic platforms from AI-enabled support tools and research-stage autonomy.

Application landscape

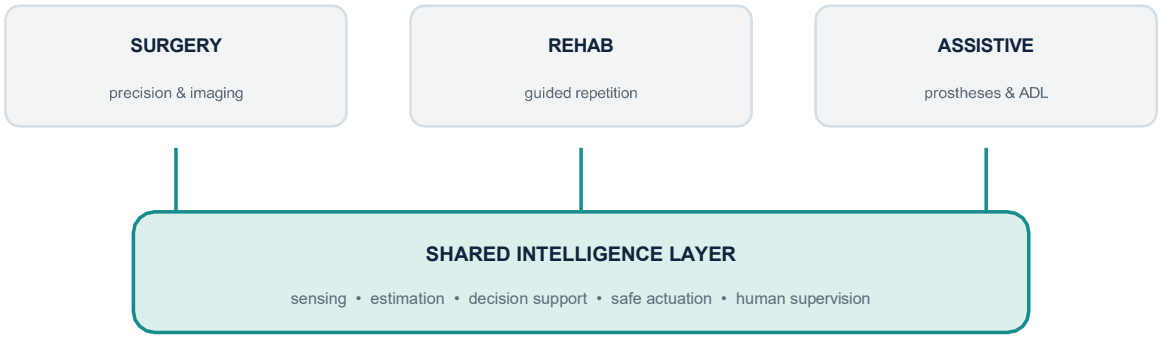


Figure 1. Three application domains share an intelligence layer, but differ in task, risk and required human oversight.

Report structure

The report moves from enabling technologies to surgery, rehabilitation and assistive systems, then evaluates evidence, safety, governance and future directions. References are listed at the end; the stated word count covers the main-body paragraphs only.

1. Introduction

Medical robotics combines mechanical systems, sensors, control engineering and clinical practice to support procedures or restore function. Artificial intelligence (AI) adds methods for interpreting images and signals, estimating patient or instrument state, recognizing movement patterns and adapting assistance. The result is not one autonomous “medical robot,” but a family of systems whose capabilities range from surgeon-controlled instruments to clinician-supervised rehabilitation devices and research prototypes. The distinction matters: a robot can be highly automated in a narrow task while remaining under continuous human control.

AI is most useful where a clinical task generates complex data or requires repeated adjustment. In surgery, that may mean identifying anatomy in an endoscopic image or quantifying instrument motion. In rehabilitation, it may mean estimating whether a patient is initiating a movement and adjusting support. In assistive technology, it may mean translating residual muscle activity into a prosthetic command. Across all three, AI should be evaluated as part of a complete human–machine system, not as a stand-alone algorithm [1], [2].

2. AI technologies and how they contribute

Machine learning (ML) learns statistical relationships from examples. In medical robotics it can classify movement patterns, estimate patient effort, predict task phases or support risk-aware planning. Deep learning, a family of ML methods using multi-layer neural networks, is particularly useful for high-dimensional inputs such as video, ultrasound or time-series sensor signals. Its performance depends on representative training data; a model trained on one hospital, camera angle or patient population may not generalize to another.

Computer vision converts images into information about the scene. Convolutional networks and transformer-based models can segment tissue, identify instruments, track landmarks or estimate limb pose. In an operating room, vision may provide scene awareness or overlay preoperative information; in rehabilitation, it can estimate shoulder, elbow and wrist motion without attaching a sensor to every segment. Occlusion, lighting changes, blood, reflective instruments and unusual anatomy can still cause errors. A vision estimate should therefore carry a confidence measure and be checked against other sensors where movement safety depends on it.

Sensor fusion combines complementary measurements. A camera provides global spatial context but may lose a limb behind the torso; an inertial measurement unit (IMU) measures angular velocity and acceleration but drifts when integrated;

joint encoders measure robot configuration, while force or torque sensors reveal physical interaction. A Kalman-family filter or probabilistic estimator can combine these signals, account for uncertainty and produce a more stable state estimate than any single sensor. Fusion does not eliminate bias: calibration errors and correlated sensor failures must be considered.

Reinforcement learning (RL) learns a policy through interaction with an environment and a reward signal. It is being investigated for adaptive assistance and robotic control, but unconstrained trial-and-error is inappropriate around patients. Research systems therefore rely on simulation, offline data, constrained action spaces and safety layers before any clinical evaluation. Human–robot interaction (HRI) is equally important: the system must communicate its intent, respond predictably to patient effort, and allow a clinician to pause or override it.

From raw signals to safe action



Figure 2. Conceptual AI-enabled medical robot pipeline. AI estimation informs assistance; an independent safety layer constrains actuation

3. AI-assisted surgical robotics

Commercial surgical robots have expanded minimally invasive surgery by translating a surgeon's hand movements into instrument motion, filtering tremor, scaling movement and providing magnified three-dimensional visualization. The da Vinci platform is a representative deployed system: the surgeon operates from a console and remains responsible for instrument movement; the robot does not independently decide or perform the operation [3]. Newer systems add force-sensing, workflow analytics or improved visualization. These features should not be confused with autonomous surgery.

AI research in surgery focuses on perception and decision support around the surgeon. Video models can recognize instruments, anatomy, procedural phases and surgical gestures. Image registration can align preoperative scans with an intraoperative view; computer vision can help track tools or highlight regions of interest. ML can also summarize operative data for training and performance feedback. A 2024 review describes opportunities across preoperative, intraoperative and postoperative care, while emphasizing that surgical AI remains at an early stage in many applications [4]. A separate review of AI in robotic surgery discusses force metrics, margin detection and automation of selected subtasks, not replacement of the surgeon [5].

The evidence ladder is important. Commercially deployed surgeon-controlled robotic platforms are established. Some AI-enabled imaging and planning tools have received regulatory authorization, but authorization of an AI device does not imply that an entire surgical robot is autonomous. The FDA's public AI-enabled device list is a useful, non-exhaustive catalogue of devices authorized in the United States; it is not a ranking of clinical benefit or autonomy [6]. Research-stage systems include automated camera positioning, skill assessment and phase-aware assistance. Fully autonomous tissue manipulation remains an emerging and tightly constrained research direction.

4. Robotic rehabilitation and assistive systems

Rehabilitation robots deliver repeatable movement, support limb weight, provide resistance or guide a patient through task-oriented practice. End-effector devices act through a handle or interface; exoskeletons align mechanical joints with anatomical segments. Sensors can record range of motion, speed, smoothness, force and task success. AI may classify movement quality, detect compensatory trunk motion, estimate effort or adapt assistance to the patient's changing capacity. The clinician still selects the exercise, sets boundaries and interprets progress.

Commercial examples demonstrate the distinction between robotics and AI. Hocoma's ArmeoPower is described as a motorized arm orthosis that supports arm weight, assists movement as needed and provides functional exercises and objective measures such as range of motion and movement quality [7]. Such product descriptions establish available device functions, not proof that a proprietary deep-learning model is clinically superior. In gait rehabilitation, EksoNR is an FDA-cleared powered exoskeleton for specified rehabilitation populations and supervised use; its clearance is not evidence for an AI-driven upper-limb system [8].

Clinical evidence is mixed and depends on comparator, dose, device and outcome. A 2024 systematic review and meta-analysis of upper-limb robots after stroke assessed randomized trials and highlighted that effects vary with intervention and patient characteristics [9]. A 2025 meta-analysis of 54 studies and 2,744 participants reported a small short-term advantage in upper-limb capacity over dose-matched conventional therapy (standardized mean difference 0.14), but the effect was not maintained at follow-up and activities-of-daily-living outcomes did not differ significantly [10]. This argues for measuring functional transfer and durability, not simply counting repetitions or device use.

DOMAIN	TYPICAL ROBOTIC ROLE	AI CONTRIBUTION	MATURITY
Surgery	Surgeon-controlled instruments; image-guided platforms	Recognition, segmentation, workflow and feedback	Commercial robotics; AI features vary
Rehabilitation	Guided, resisted or supported practice	Pose/effort estimation and adaptive assistance	Commercial robots; AI personalization developing
Assistive	Prostheses and mobility support	Signal classification and intent decoding	Mixed; ML remains largely research-stage

Table 1. Application maturity is described at the platform/function level; it should not be read as evidence that each platform contains autonomous AI.

5. Benefits, limitations and responsible deployment

Potential benefits include consistent delivery of repetitive practice, quantitative measurement, reduced physical burden on therapists, improved visualization and more individualized feedback. Robots may make high-repetition training feasible for some patients who cannot complete the same movement independently. AI may help identify subtle changes and tune assistance, but only if its measurements are valid and the intervention improves outcomes that matter to patients: independence, participation, comfort and quality of life.

Technical limitations include domain shift, incomplete or noisy labels, small datasets, class imbalance, sensor drift, latency, calibration burden and poor interpretability. A model may confuse compensation with recovery—for example, a patient may reach a target by leaning the trunk rather than improving selective arm control. False confidence is particularly hazardous when AI output influences force or trajectory. Performance must be tested across age, impairment severity, body size, skin tone, assistive devices, clinical sites and real-world operating conditions.

Safety is a system property. Mechanical hazards include excessive force, joint misalignment, entrapment, unexpected motion and failure to release. Software hazards include incorrect state estimation, corrupted data, unsafe updates and cybersecurity compromise. Risk management should identify hazards, estimate and evaluate risk, implement controls and monitor residual risk throughout the device lifecycle, as set out in ISO 14971:2019 [11]. Rehabilitation robots that physically interact with patients fall within the scope of IEC 80601-2-78:2019, with Amendment 1:2024 [12]. Electrical safety, electromagnetic compatibility, usability engineering, software lifecycle and cybersecurity standards may also apply depending on the device and jurisdiction.

Ethical governance requires informed consent, privacy, fairness, transparency and accountability. Video and physiological data can reveal identity and health status; collection should be minimized, access controlled and retention justified. Training

datasets should represent intended users, and subgroup performance should be reported. The WHO's 2021 guidance places human rights and accountability at the centre of AI for health [1]. Its 2023 regulatory considerations emphasize intended use, external validation, transparency, lifecycle monitoring, data quality and cybersecurity [2]. In the United States, the FDA's 2025 guidance on predetermined change control plans explains how planned modifications to AI-enabled device software can be documented and evaluated while maintaining reasonable assurance of safety and effectiveness [13]. Regulatory authorization is jurisdiction- and intended-use-specific; a product cleared in one country is not automatically approved in Pakistan.

6. Future directions and conclusion

Near-term progress is likely to come from better sensing, multimodal models, explainable feedback, shared-control interfaces and clinically meaningful datasets rather than unrestricted autonomy. Digital twins and simulation may support preclinical testing, while federated or privacy-preserving learning may help institutions collaborate without pooling identifiable data. These approaches introduce their own validation and governance demands. Future studies should use prospective, adequately powered designs, transparent protocols, clinically relevant comparators and follow-up long enough to assess whether gains persist and transfer to daily activities.

AI-enabled medical robotics is best understood as augmentation: machines can improve precision, consistency, measurement and personalization, while clinicians contribute context, judgment, consent and responsibility. The strongest applications are those with a clearly bounded task, validated sensing, predictable control and an effective human override. Claims of autonomous surgery or guaranteed recovery exceed the evidence. Responsible progress depends not only on algorithmic accuracy but also on safe mechanics, robust evaluation, equitable access and accountable clinical integration.

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